



Robots can feel

From MIT and Northeastern University, researchers are developing sensors that would let robots see what they are touching <http://dgit.in/FingertipSensor>

Rise of Precrime?

Researchers are trying to predict crimes in London using cell phone data. How? Find out: <http://dgit.in/PredictingCrime>

En Garde!

As internet security becomes a major concern, users need to be more careful than ever

Requests for user data rise by 150% in 5 years: Google

Transparency reports from Internet companies indicate that governments across the world are trying to access your information and even asking to take down content they deem objectionable. Considering how upfront and transparent users and Internet companies are, you'd expect the number of such requests to decline over a period of time. Unfortunately, the number of requests have grown, and not by a negligible figure but by a whopping 150 percent in the past five years.

This is one of the statistics from Google's 10th transparency report, that reveals yet another sharp increase in the number of government user data requests since Google's first report in 2009.

The search engine giant revealed that it received 32,000 requests in the first half of 2014 – up 15 percent from the

previous report. Google stated that it provided some data in 65 percent of the cases. The highest number of requests were made by governments in the US (12,539), followed by Germany (3,338), France (3,002) and India (2,794). U.S. saw a 19 percent increase in the first half of this year compared to the previous six months and up nearly 250 percent since 2009.

Indian Govt. spying on users?

A recent Software Freedom Law Centre (SFLC) report called 'India's Surveillance State' claims that the Indian government has violated the privacy of over one lakh users in a year.

The report was presented at the Internet Governance Forum held in Istanbul. Conducted by SFLC, a non-profit legal services organisation, the study was prepared on the basis of RTI replies given by the government, which included replies to 26 companies who expressed interest



Are we all being spied on?

in setting up Internet monitoring systems for the central government. These included companies offering "far more potent surveillance technologies including phone interception, social media network analysis and data mining and profiling".

"On an average, more than a lakh of telephone interception orders are issued by the central government alone every year. On adding the surveillance orders issued by the State Governments to this, it becomes clear that India routinely surveils her citizens' communications on a truly staggering scale," the 68-page report said.

The state surveillance of citizens' private communications is authorised by legislative enactments such as the Indian Telegraph Act and the Information Technology Act that allows Indian law enforcement agencies to closely monitor phone calls, messages, emails and general Internet activity on a number of grounds.

However, India is yet to put into place a legal framework explicitly for protecting individuals' privacy.

Govt. may ban Gmail, Yahoo! email services for official use

India's Department of Electronics and Information Technology (DeitY) has proposed to

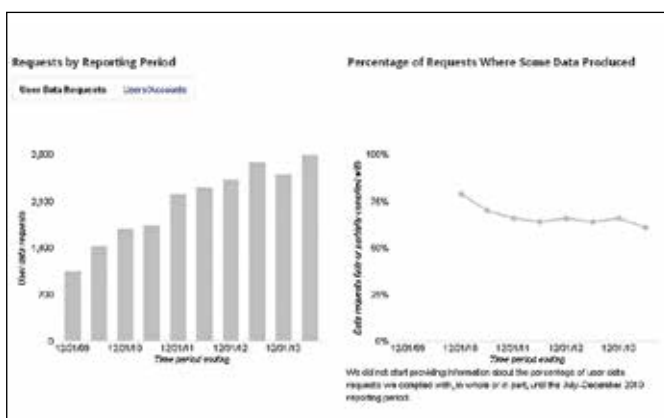
ban foreign email services such as Gmail, Yahoo! Hotmail, etc. for official use to safeguard critical and sensitive government data.

According to sources, all Government communications, apart from those of Ministry of External Affairs and Defence, may soon be carried out on the platform by NIC at nic.in. The Defence Ministry already has its own separate secure email server and the External Affairs may soon follow suit.

The proposal has been made to protect the large amount of critical government data that gets exchanged. The policy will cover over 5-6 lakh central and state government employees. At the time of writing, the proposal will be presented by DeitY for cabinet approval by the end of September.

DeitY will require about ₹4-5 crores to update NIC's infrastructure and ensure smooth working of the NIC platform. Apart from that, a total investment of around ₹50-100 crores would be required for full operationability of the policy. The proposal has been made amidst concerns about rising cybercrime and hacking incidents. Recently, five million Google usernames and passwords were leaked online by Russian hackers.

Last year, a similar proposal



Summary of requests from India